DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Potential and Actual: Where Do the Limits of Evil Begin?

Daat Tevunot §115-116

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** Review of §114, then §115-116 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 20 March 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: how evil comes about

The class began on page 254 with a review. Evil cannot come directly from HaKadosh Barukh Hu, because the good cannot produce bad. It must come from a lack of hashpaah, a lack of illumination. A participant's analogy from the last class was a knob on a dial: the more the light is turned down, the more imperfection.

That explains why a person is born deaf, blind or lame. The problem was how to explain things that are actively bad, like cancer, where bad cells attack good ones. The Rabbi asked whether anyone had read the two pages of English commentary.

The two stages, as the class understood them

A participant summarised: in the first stage there was already withdrawal, which allowed undifferentiated elements of evil; in the second stage the system broke, things settled into good and evil, and evil gained its own autonomy. The Rabbi confirmed: "That's what the Ramhal says."

So when a person is born imperfect, that is the first stage, the withdrawal of light. When something actively bad happens, like cancer cells, that is the second stage, where what was withdrawn has taken on its own identity and gone on to create things.

Asked how even earthquakes can be explained, the Rabbi drew a line. We are not discussing why bad things happen. There are many reasons for that, and we will come to them. Here we ask only how: how can a perfect, good God create evil at all?

Frankenstein and the golem

A participant compared it to a horror film, and then to Frankenstein. The Rabbi liked the analogy. He explained the word golem: it means an unfinished lump, as a potter takes a golem and shapes things from it. The golem of Prague, like Frankenstein, was meant to be unfinished and controlled, but went rogue. "I'm withdrawing, so I'm allowing the elements of bad to exist, but then boom! They take on their own identity."

Does Hashem remain in control? Can He stop it? These questions, he said, belong to the next part.

§115: the boundaries of evil

On page 254 the Neshamah thanks the Sekhel (§115): you have helped me understand how evil comes about. Now explain its boundaries. The Rabbi said this was exactly a participant's earlier question about how far evil can go.

§116: potential and actual

The Sekhel first needs a further introduction (§116), and the Rabbi explained it in his own words before reading it.

What is the difference between potential and actual? Potential means something can happen; actual means it does. Now: before the universe existed, whenever you believe that was, was there a potential for the universe? The Rabbi stressed that we should not speak too much about what came before creation, so he kept it brief.

When we say a child has great potential, we mean that right now he does not have it, but if he changes, he can achieve it. The idea of potential carries within it the idea of change. And there is no change in HaKadosh Barukh Hu. So there is no concept of potential before the universe. Potential and actual are themselves created along with the universe.

The Ramhal says: Hashem could have done everything we described whenever He wished, since He does not change. We do not say there was always a potential for existence, or for evil, that had to be actualised. That, says the Ramhal, is one of the mistakes of the philosophers. The Rabbi identified this as Aristotle, who held that the world was eternal: since nothing can change, the world must always have been there.

But before the universe you cannot speak of potential or actual at all. When Hashem created the world, He created the very concept of potential and actual, and He made the world first in potential and then in actuality.

Bereshit: everything on the first day

The Ramhal brings the words of Hazal that "Bereshit" is also one of the ten sayings of creation. On the first day everything was created in potential, and from there everything came out into actuality. The Rabbi reminded the class that they had discussed this before: on day one the whole universe is there, latent, and then Hashem says "now come out", and it emerges. On the first day He also created the very possibility of potential and actual.

How this relates to the two stages of evil, he said, would come on Thursday.

A word on learning in order

When someone who had arrived partway through tried to jump ahead, the Rabbi gently said that one cannot come into the middle and expect to understand everything "on one foot". The book is built brick upon brick, which is why he kept insisting on revision.

Summary

- Evil arises in two stages: a withdrawal that makes things imperfect, and a later stage where what was withdrawn takes on its own identity and acts.
- Like a golem or Frankenstein, what was allowed to exist can "go rogue"; whether Hashem remains in control is the next question.
- §115: the Neshamah now asks about the boundaries of evil.
- §116: potential and actual are created things; before creation there was no potential, since potential implies change and God does not change.
- On the first day everything was created in potential, and then emerged into actuality.

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